

1.7.1 The pre-upgrade stage

1. Verify the minimum requirements for the hardware and system configuration.

While Microsoft's official recommendation is for a 300 MHz Pentium processor with 128 MB of RAM, experts and practical experience suggest you should at least have a Pentium III 500 MHz processor with at least 256 MB of RAM. Otherwise, Windows XP will be sluggish. In addition, you should have at least 1 or 2 GB of free hard disk space on your primary partition (the C: drive in most cases), an SVGA monitor that can support a screen resolution of 800 x 600 or higher, a display card, a sound card, a modem, and a CD or DVD drive. The sound card and modem are not essential, but you will want to connect to the Internet and update XP with all the latest patches once installation is complete, so a modem is required sooner or later. The sound card is preferable for your audio feedback (XP Setup sounds and music) at different stages of the setup process.

2. Which file system?

During setup, XP will ask you if you want to convert to NTFS from FAT/FAT32. FAT or FAT32 is the file system on which Windows 98/ME runs. NTFS is a newer, more robust file system used by both Windows 2000 and XP. Be warned, however, that this is a one-way street. If you convert to NTFS, you cannot convert back to FAT, and if you want to make your system a dual-boot, i.e. you want to be able to boot into either XP or Windows 98/ME, you will not be able to log into Windows 98/ME. The same goes if you want to uninstall XP and revert to your previous Windows version after converting to NTFS.

During setup, it is best to leave it as FAT32, and later, after you have stopped relying on Windows 98/ME completely, you can convert from FAT32 to NTFS. In Windows XP, open a command prompt and type in "convert/?" to get details of the FAT32 to NTFS conversion process.